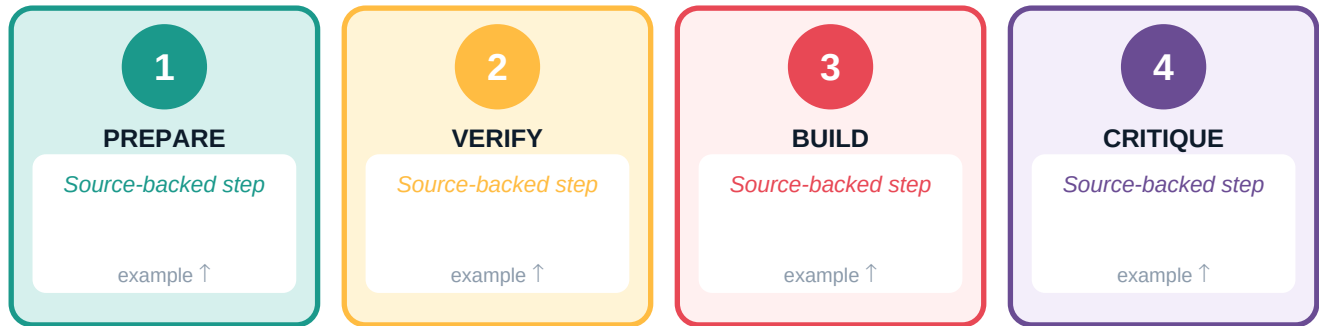


CHAPTER 23

Building Your AI Habits



WHY HABITS MATTER MORE THAN TECHNIQUES Every technique in this book is available to you from today. The 7 Questions, the Before -> Better -> Best approach, the critique loop, the verification framework, all of them can be applied immediately.

But techniques that aren't habitual are techniques that get used occasionally, in high-stakes situations, when you remember, and not used the rest of the time. The people who get the most consistent value from AI are not necessarily the most technically sophisticated. They are the people who have built consistent habits that apply the right practices automatically.

This chapter is about building those habits.

THE FOUR HABITS THAT MATTER MOST From watching how people build effective AI practices, four habits account for most of the difference between occasional useful results and consistently good output:

HABIT 1, PREPARE BEFORE YOU PROMPT The single biggest quality leverage point is the thirty seconds spent applying the 7 Questions before starting a significant AI task. Most people skip this and type whatever is on their mind. Those who make it habitual find that they invest slightly more time upfront and substantially less time in revision.

Make it automatic: for any AI task that involves more than a few minutes of work, run the 7 Questions first. Even quickly. Even imperfectly. The discipline of asking "what am I trying to achieve?" before typing is worth far more than any clever prompt technique.

HABIT 2, VERIFY BEFORE YOU USE Establish a consistent minimum verification standard for any output you will use professionally. The specific standard depends on the stakes of your work, but the habit is non-negotiable: before you send, publish, present, or act on significant AI output, you have checked something.

For most professional use, the minimum is: read critically, check any numbers and specific facts, and confirm the output follows the constraints you set. This takes two to five minutes. Make it as automatic as saving a file.

HABIT 3, BUILD YOUR WORKSPACE ITERATIVELY Your AI workspace is not something you set up once and leave. It improves every time you notice a gap, every time AI gets something wrong that it would have got right with better standing instructions, every time you re-type context you've already established, every time you use a prompt that worked particularly well.

The habit: when something goes wrong that a better workspace would have prevented, fix the workspace. When you write a prompt that works especially well, save it. When you notice you're re-entering the same context repeatedly, persist it. Small iterative improvements to your workspace compound into significant efficiency gains over time.

HABIT 4, CRITIQUE BEFORE YOU FINISH Before finalising any significant piece of AI-assisted work, run it through a critique pass. This doesn't need to be formal, it can be as simple as asking AI "what is weak about this?" and reading the response with genuine openness.

People who skip this step send proposals with obvious structural weaknesses, publish articles with underdeveloped arguments, and submit reports with claims that don't hold up. People who make critique a habit catch these things before they matter.

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BUILDING HABITS: THE PRACTICAL APPROACH Knowing what the habits are is not the same as having them. Three approaches help:

ATTACH HABITS TO EXISTING TRIGGERS. Link new AI habits to things you already do. Before opening ChatGPT for a task: run the 7 Questions. Before closing a document you've used AI to help produce: run the verification checklist. The existing action becomes the trigger for the new habit.

START SMALLER THAN FEELS NECESSARY. A habit that takes thirty seconds and is done every time is more valuable than a thorough process that is done occasionally. Begin with the minimum viable version of each habit. Add complexity as it becomes automatic.

REVIEW PERIODICALLY. Once a month, look at what you're using AI for and ask: is my practice serving me well? What am I getting that's consistently poor quality? What am I spending time verifying that I could build into my workspace? What technique from this book have I not tried yet that might help?

A WEEK IN THE LIFE OF A CALIBRATED AI USER To make this concrete, here is what a week of integrated AI use looks like for someone with established habits:

Monday morning:

Preparing for a client review meeting. Opens the client's Project. Pastes in the latest project data and asks AI for a status summary. Reviews it against his own knowledge, catches one outdated figure. Uses the agenda workflow (W8). Both ready in thirty minutes.

Tuesday:



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Needs to draft a challenging email to a supplier about a missed deadline. Runs the 7 Questions briefly. Uses W1. Reviews the draft, adjusts the tone. Sends within twenty minutes of starting.

Wednesday:

Writing a quarterly business report. Starts with the Information -> Structure -> Content pattern (Chapter 17). Reviews the structure before drafting. Runs a critique loop on the draft (Chapter 18). Verifies the two financial figures independently. Done in two hours rather than half a day.

Thursday:

Reviewing a contract. Uses W22. Checks the flag list AI produces against her solicitor's advice. Updates her standing workspace instructions to include a note about a contract clause type she should always flag.

Friday:

Reflecting on the week. One output needed correction, AI got a date wrong. Updates her personal verification checklist to add "verify dates in contract summaries." Small improvement. Compounds over time.

PRO TIP THE MOST POWERFUL SINGLE THING YOU CAN DO THIS WEEK

set up your persistent instructions if you haven't already. Spend thirty minutes writing a context document that covers your professional context, communication preferences, standard audience, and key constraints. Paste it into every AI session this week and notice how much setup time you save. Then move it into your platform's persistent instructions setting so it applies automatically.

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WHAT GOOD AI USE DOES NOT LOOK LIKE It is worth being explicit about the patterns that look like productive AI use but aren't:

Prompt collecting without application. Building a library of prompts from the internet and using them once before returning to the same vague requests as before.

Volume without quality. Generating large quantities of AI output and editing it all manually because it's not quite right, faster to produce, slower overall because verification and correction eat the time savings.

Outsourcing judgment. Using AI to make decisions that require accountability. AI can inform decisions; it cannot make them on your behalf.

Ignoring failure patterns. Noticing that AI consistently gets something wrong and continuing to rely on it in that area without verification or adjustment.

Treating the first draft as final. The first AI output on a complex task is almost never the best it can be. One iteration, a critique loop, a refinement pass, a targeted revision, consistently improves it.



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